

The

GRAY THINGIE

By Maximo



For nearly 10 years I have been building slot cars for Maximo. (His real name is being withheld for personal protection) The only requirement is that the cars be creative in design, maintain a theme and based on Thingie bodies from the late 1960's.

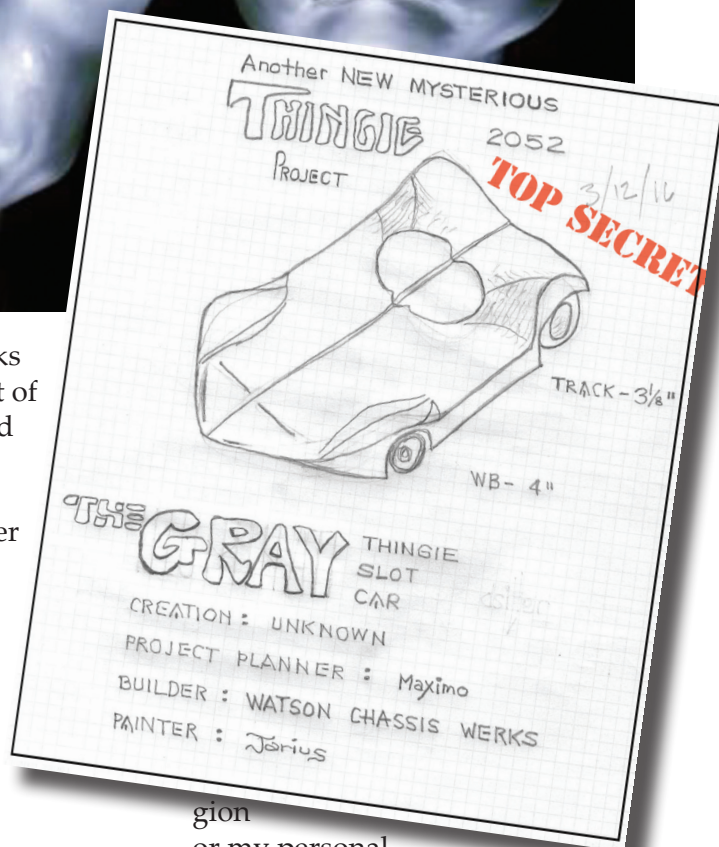
At first the bodies were reproductions of original bodies from that time period such as those produced by Choti and Shinoda. Later, a lot of the current crop of vacuum formers began making their own creative bodies and the race was on!

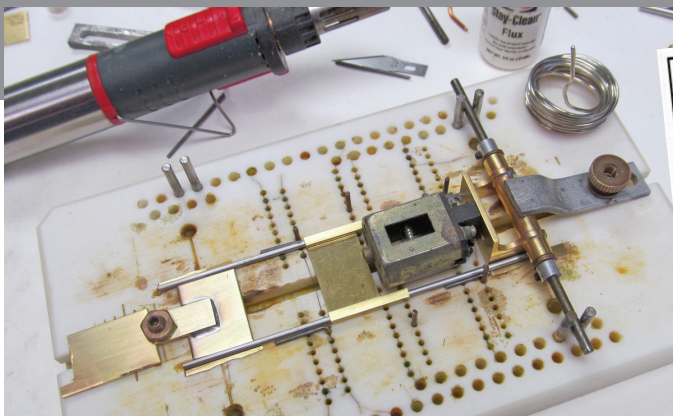
Such is the case with this project we have called "The Grey". The body is based on an Italian body called "Le Bostella", but with a modified cockpit featuring two large canopies suggesting bugged out eyes. Not sure who vacuum

formed it... but it looks very much like my set of Le Bostella coupes and roadsters so... it was probably molded by the same Italian former who made the originals. But, it was Max who came up with the idea of turning the body paint into a representation of what some would call "Alien".

Everyone by now recognizes the face. Movies have been made with their distinctive countenance featured. One video was a comedy produced involving a motor home with the alien poking fun of my personal religion. Now, it makes me no never mind if Hollyweird pokes fun at politics, reli-

gion or my personal favorite food. (Pizza) But when it comes to slot cars, I'll pretty much build anything for a friend with inspirational ideas. This does open pandora's box about whether I believe in Aliens or not of course. That answer is yes. Not as extraterrestrial beings from Mars or another planet, but





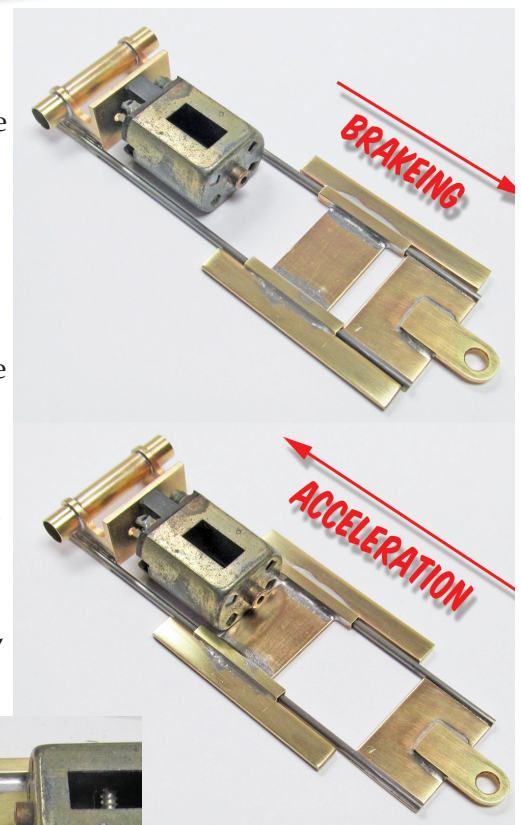
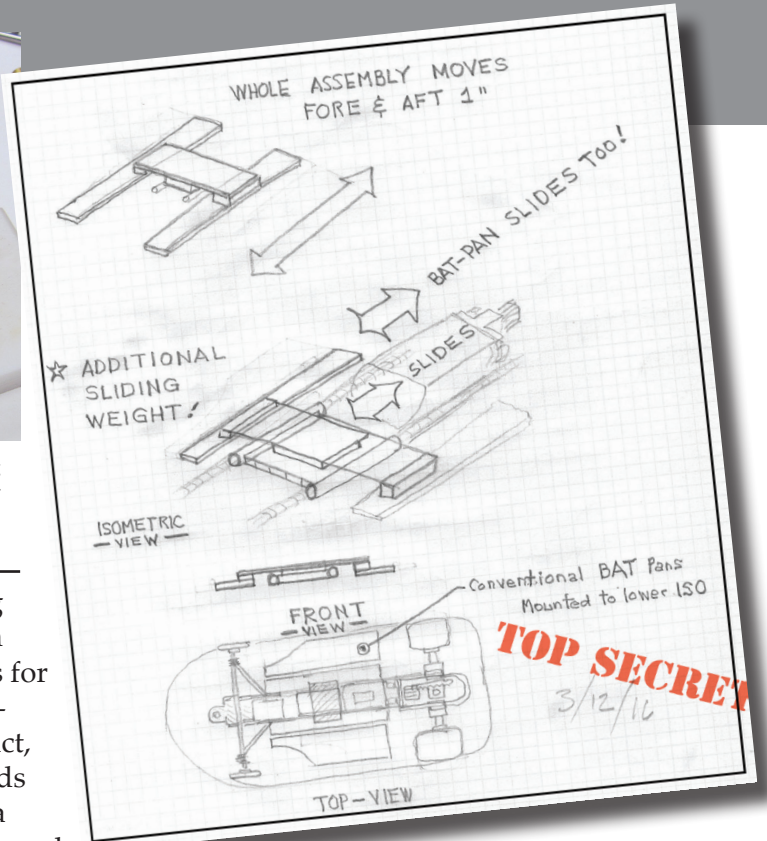
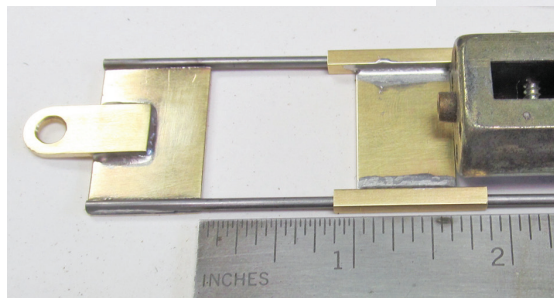
Motor bracket is soldered up with a brass tube to hold the bearings first, then the rest of the bits are added to the center section with a jig holding all the parts in place prior to adding heat. This time a torch was the primary tool due to the thickness of the brass.

as inter-dimensional existing in another realm using their "alien grey" bodies as a "skin suit" to exist in our realm. Too much evidence abounds to deny it, however, before we go further into the weeds. Lets get back to the slot car....

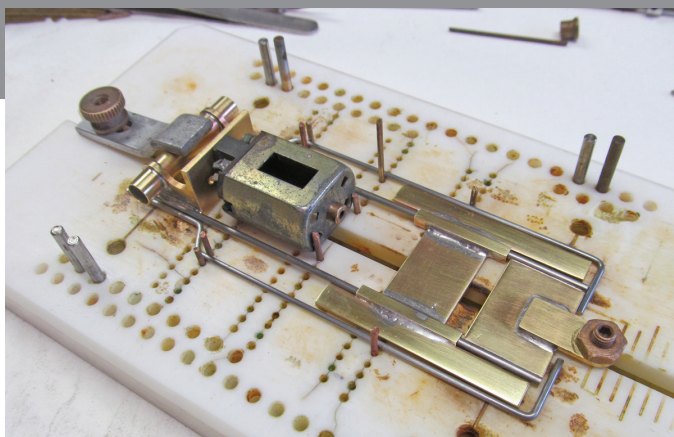
Max sends drawings (hundreds of drawings so far for the past 40 projects) in order to get his ideas across and I interpret the images in brass and steel wire best I can with-in the requirements of handling and dynamics of the slot car track. I then send him photos of the progress and either publish them here or on one of the various on-line forums. Eventually he receives the car and I receive feed back on the handling... and so it goes.

This build was no different. The drawings received included a sliding weight design called the "clicker". I've produced this effect before so it's not totally innovative since the idea was based on a brainstorm from 1971. The moveable weight accomplishes two effects: first it slides forward during braking shifting weight into the slot to eliminate desolating. Second it shifts rearward during accel-

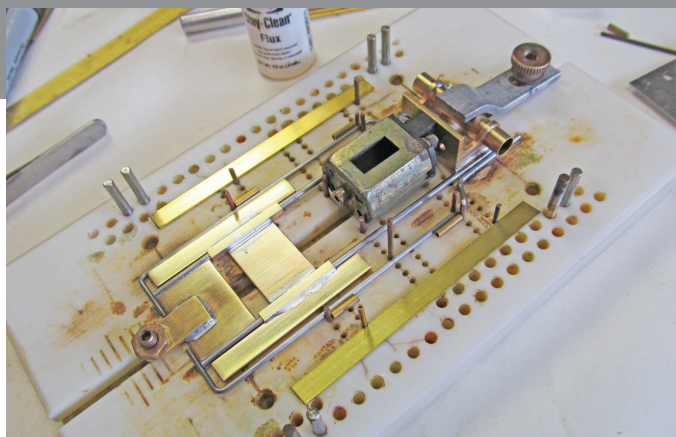
eration shifting weight back on the rear wheels for traction. To accomplish this act, the weight needs to move quite a distance and according to the drawings I was suppose to give it one full inch of travel. Best I could accomplish was 7/8", but that was way more radical than the car built in 1971 which only managed 1/8 of an inch travel. However, the other beneficial effect is in cancelation of vibration caused by rear wheel hop. This is the reason why cars since 1965 have had floppy pans and other such chassis movements. But that sliding weight accomplishes the same thing provided the tubes are not too tight on the rails. So... combined with floppy pans and a big rewind 16d motor.... I think "The Grey" may surprise us all.



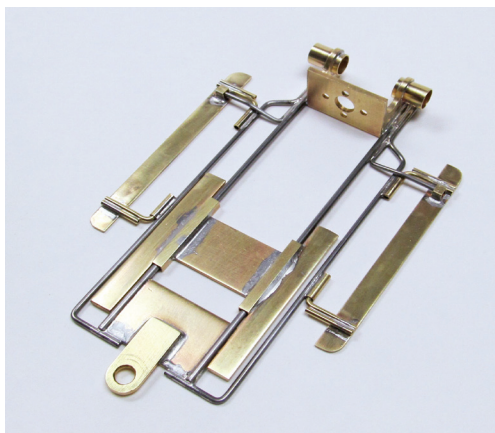
Main rails are .078 with the slider tubes .095 I.D. square brass providing plenty of room. Forward plate and tongue are .062, same as the cross plate of the slider. The side sliders are a beefy .078 thick.



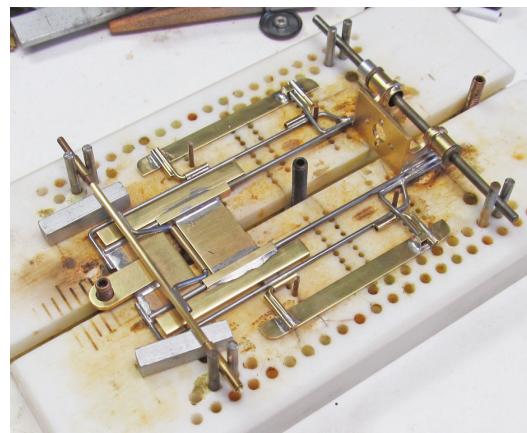
Once the center section is done, we turn our attention to the pan rails. These are .062 steel wire bent as shown in order to provide a solid mounting location for the pan hinge tubes.



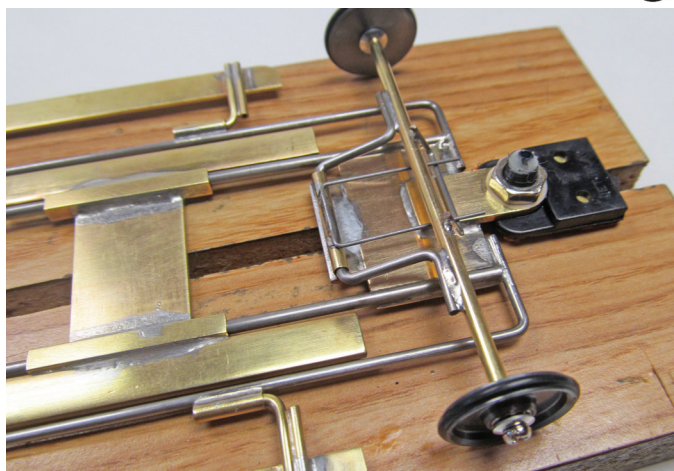
Pans are simply .032 brass strip. No need for anything heavier since the slider is so husky. But we do want them solid enough to survive and hold the body secure. At this point everything looks good in the jig, time for a hot iron!



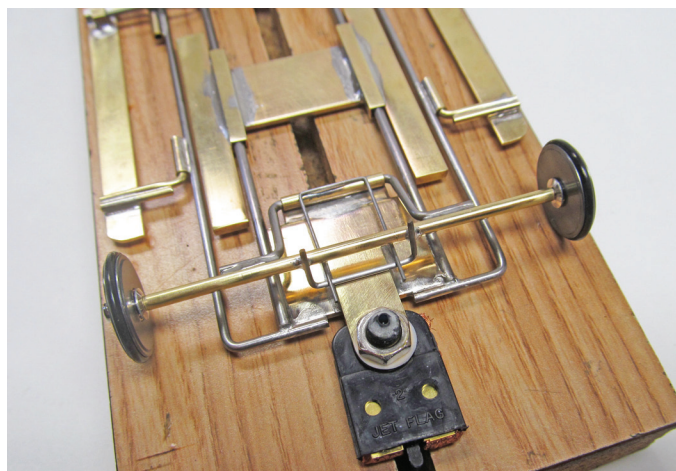
Pans are now hung and include hinges, down stops and pin tubes.



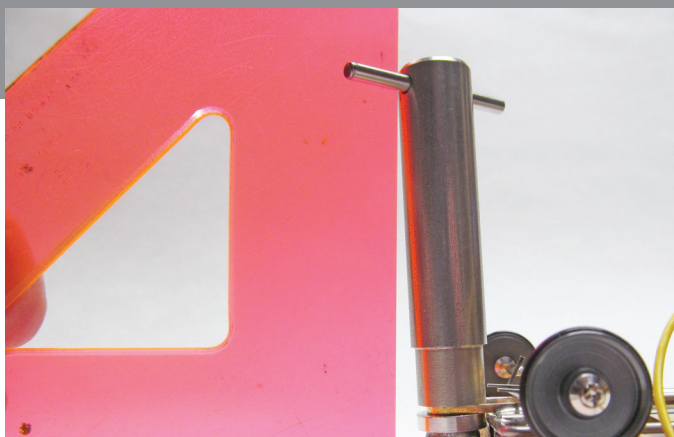
Front axle is what we are concentrating on here. I had little idea when I made the center section what I would do for the front axle. But I usually make this stuff up as I go along anyway.



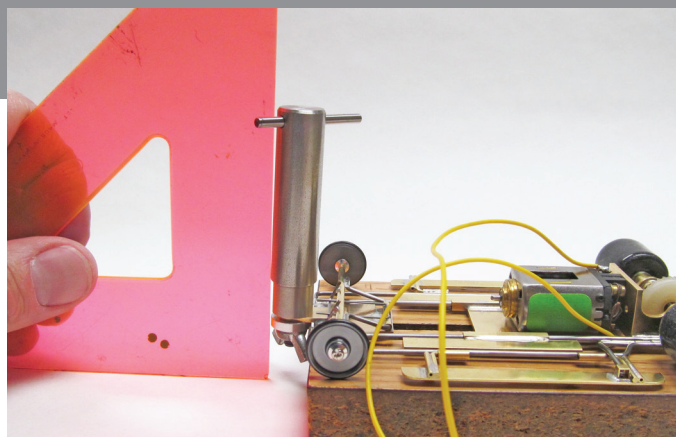
Customer mentioned he wanted the front axle to be slightly adjustable so I provided an ISO which provides about .062 of travel. That's enough to keep the front wheels rolling on both a flush or recessed braid track



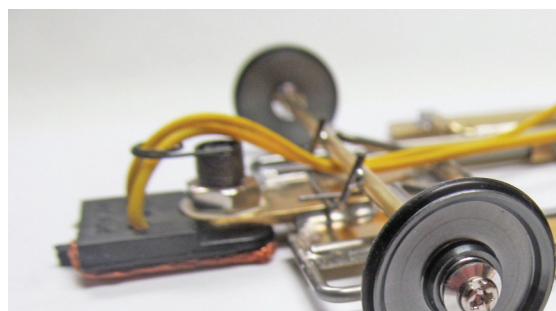
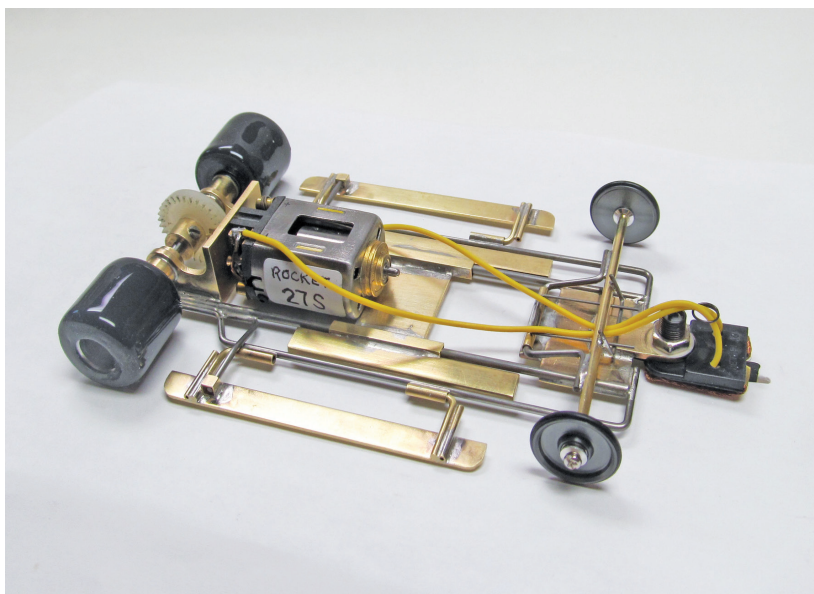
The "U" shape is a down stop and pressure point for the spring made with .025 steel wire. It also will help locate the lead wires. The front wheels are made by Tamiya for some of their 1/25th scale RC cars and they come with ball bearings. Very low friction!



This chassis set-up trick should be preformed on on any car you are building. The angle of the guide determines how smoothly it slides down the slot and where the nose pressure will concentrate. The weight should press primarily down right at the guide pivot. As you can see..... I was off by that much!



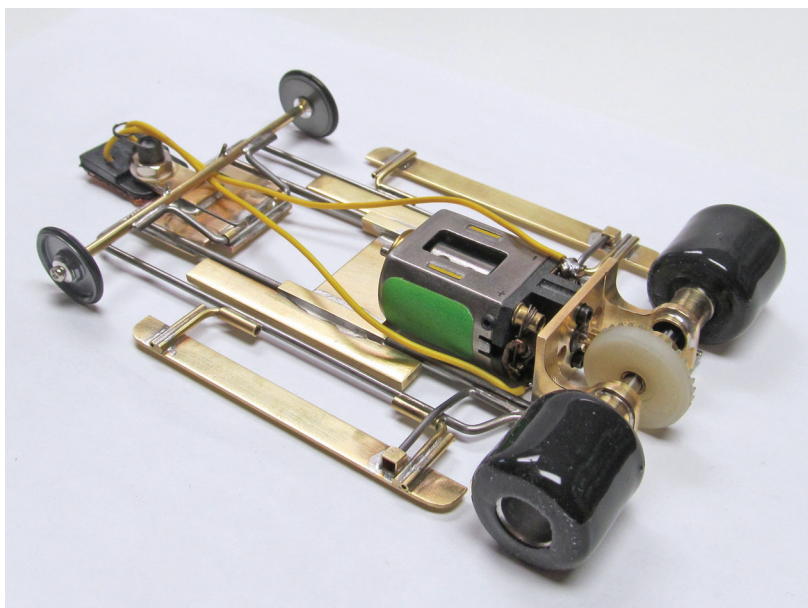
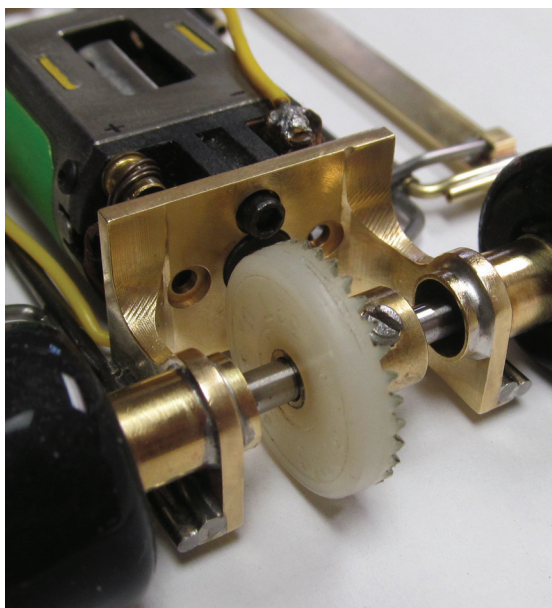
The tool bolts directly to the guide tongue in place of the guide flag and provides enough leverage to bend the tongue back behind the hole so it won't effect the flag and guide retainer. A good one or two degree tilt back is just right. Now the car will shoot down the slot smoothly.



So now we have a finished chassis.

Above: a note about the guide wires. That little loopy thing is from mid 60's Dynamic. It places the pivot point of the wire back away from where it enters the flag to eliminate a broken wire problem.

Below left: Bench testing for a few minutes helped work in the gear mesh. Sometimes warming the gear while the power is on with a lighter helps.



Painting the GRAY

This body is formed from PETG which is the same material blister packs electrical and other retail items are sold packaged in hanging on hooks at the store. The material is used because it softens at lower temperatures and won't hurt most molds.

Lexan is way more durable but requires higher heat to mold. Most modern slot car bodies from major manufacturers are Lexan since they put up with the rigors of a hard race but PETG is easier to mold with and so

some independent vacuum formers prefer it. Except that PETG bodies should only be painted with enamel or water base paints as lacquers will soak in and the chemicals make the plastic brittle and subject to splitting. That said... it is possible to paint a body with lacquer if it is shot "dry". Meaning light coats and allowing long dry times.

Okay... so in painting "The Grey", the first step was drawing out the face with a Sharpie pen. I use the Sharpie because it can be cleaned off with rubbing alcohol later.

Then the face is masked off and a black background lightly sprayed. The second step is backing up with Parma Faskolor silver.

Masking tape is removed and some light shadows added. I then backed that up with silver but didn't like the look so I masked up the face and eyes on the OUTSIDE of the body and shot some light coats of dullkote. It really helped separate the shiny body from the face leaving the eyes shiny. So... while it was still masked up I pulled out some flat white and flat black enamels and added some more shadows and highlights being careful not to make it too white.

Later some brushed on enamel flat black was used to add nostrils, a mouth and eye lids. Light grey One-Shot was used to letter the cars name and it was done!





Parts Sources:

Motor:

John Havlicek rewind 27s

Rear bracket:

Paul's Slots (paulstubradio@gmail.com)

Crown gear:

Vintage Johnson 32t

Front wheels:

17mm TAMIYA "O" ring

Rear wheels:

Silicone coated foam



Finished product doesn't look much like the scale race cars we are used to, but then, that's the nature of Thingies where art generally trumps scale features.
Ciao.

